

After a difficult, months-long vulnerability hangover, I realized that I didn't feel quite so raw anymore. My skin grew back, and it was thicker now. I felt ready to start challenging the moralizing of money and spending that had made me feel so awful, and to pull together an alternative narrative on money – one that helped people to understand their behaviour and make deeper changes, rather than attempting to shame or judge them into making superficial, punitive changes. It filled me with a new sense of purpose, and the stirrings of this book were born. I wanted to create something more than just a manual for using money – I wanted to teach people how to feel good about it. I wanted to create something that really explored the emotional and psychological side of money and health, rather than just paying lip service to it, or treating it as an irritating caveat to the usual prescriptive advice.

My relationship with money, though vastly improved from what it was, is still a work in progress, and most likely always will be. There will always be old habits that seem appealing when I'm at a low ebb, unfulfilled expectations that threaten my happiness, new temptations that try to divert my course. But learning to navigate these peaks and troughs without overwhelming anxiety or crushing despondency is at the very heart of true financial wellbeing. It's not a snapshot of a moment in time – an Instagram post holding the keys to your first home or a screenshot of those zero credit card balances – it's dynamic and ever-evolving. It's about all of the moments and experiences and decisions in between those snap-worthy